

# Whitney, Petrin and Crawford: the class of 2027

An evaluation of the three Claremont School Board members whose terms expire in March 2027

*Government Transparency Project. Prepared September 28, 2026 from the project’s meeting record (Output/HTML, Output/HTML/Dialogue, the deficit timeline of September 1, 2026 and the Elite Theory Perspective report of September 27, 2026) and the public press record. Every in-meeting citation names the recording date and the transcript timestamp; every press or statutory citation is listed under Sources.*

## 1. Scope, disclosure and how to read this

Three of the seven seats on the Claremont School Board come up on March 9, 2027. The district’s own roster lists Candace Crawford (chair), Michael Petrin (vice chair) and Heather Whitney with “Term ends 2027”; Howard and Madden run to 2028, Lavalette and Rapp to 2029 (SAU 6, Claremont board page). All three won three-year terms on March 12, 2024, in an election with no contested race: Whitney and Crawford were re-elected and Petrin returned as a write-in (Scripts/briefing.md, Era 4; deficit timeline, roster table).

The evaluation asks three questions of each member, as the request framed them: what part they played in creating or enabling the deficit; what part they played in the district’s response; and how open they have shown themselves to be to the education options catalogued at edopt.org, which lists public, charter and private schools, homeschool groups and learning centers, virtual and hybrid programs, career and technical centers, dual enrollment, tutoring and Education Freedom Account providers (EdOpt, provider directory).

**Disclosure.** The person who maintains this project, Kevin Tyson, is a co-founder and the vice chair of EdOpt (EdOpt, About page). He applied for the vacant board seat twice. On July 19, 2023 the board appointed Crawford over him and David Bailey, 4–2, with Whitney and Sprague voting no (Valley News, July 21, 2023; briefing.md, Era 3). On October 1, 2025 the board split 3–3 between him and Don Lavalette: Whitney, Petrin and Madden for Tyson; Crawford, Hawkins and Howard for Lavalette (Claremont School Board, 10/1/25, 1:35:18 to 1:35:50). That second vote is used below as evidence of each member’s attitude toward competing modalities, because the exchange that preceded it is the most direct discussion of the subject anywhere in the record. Readers should weigh the author’s interest accordingly; the evaluation tries to hold the three members to the same standard and to say when a fact cuts against the author’s side.

**Evidence tiers.** A recorded roll call fixes an individual’s position. An uncounted voice vote does not: it shows what the board did and who presided, and nothing about how any one member voted. Nearly every money decision in the deficit’s formation was a voice vote (deficit timeline, “Every major money motion in this sequence passed on an uncounted voice vote”). Where a member is credited below with a decision taken by voice vote, the credit is for presiding over it or for speaking to it, never for a vote the record does not contain. Transcripts are machine-produced and machine-attributed; sustained turns are reliable, short exchanges are not, and the meeting pages flag the known misattributions.

## 2. Summary of findings

| Member                                                                        | Role in the deficit’s formation                                                                                                                                                                                                  | Role in the response                                                                                                                                                                                    | Openness to competing modalities                                                                                                                                       |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Heather Whitney (board since March 2019; vice chair 2020 to 2023; chair March | Present for every act from 2019 onward. Vice chair for the three unrecorded autumn filings (2020, 2021, 2022). Chair for the 2023 retention, its 2024 reversal, the 2024 retention, the FY2026 budget built on one-time aid, the | Announced the deficit, asked for an Attorney General investigation, proposed the annual-audit and grant-documentation policies. Backed the \$4 million note, the three-school model and the flat FY2027 | The most open of the three, on the record: private-school parent by her own account; sought homeschool resources in 2020–21; raised charter partnership in 2023; voted |

| Member                                                                                                                                                            | Role in the deficit's formation                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         | Role in the response                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | Openness to competing modalities                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2023 to March 2026)                                                                                                                                               | pre-K cut, the Masonic Temple purchase and the May 2025 trust drain, all by voice vote. Voted against the February 2023 ESSER-cliff restoration on a roll call.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         | budget. Telephoned Sprague and voted to reinstate him. In 2026, chairs reconfiguration, filed Right-to-Know requests, put 13 written questions to the auditor.                                                                                                                                                                        | for an EdOpt founder in 2025 saying "public education is in a rut." Views every option through its effect on district revenue.                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| Michael Petrin (board since March 2017, gap March 2023 to March 2024; SAU 6 chair 2019–20; Claremont chair April 2022 to March 2023; vice chair since March 2025) | On the board when the audits stopped. Chaired SAU 6 in spring 2019 when a forensic audit was presented as an option and never put to a vote, and a \$5,000 efficiency study was rejected, then deferred to the incoming superintendent. Presided as Claremont chair over the autumn 2022 filing that returned about \$1.2 million in a deficit year ("the vote was to give back 1.2 million"). Voted for the February 2023 restoration. Absent from the board for the 2023 retention and 2024 reversal. | Voted for the note, the Bluff closure, the three-school model and the flat budget. Moved Sprague's reinstatement twice. Asked on the record how a board is supposed to distrust its business administrator. Volunteered for the search committee. Thin 2026 record: absent or not identifiable at several meetings.                   | Not hostile; transactional. Asked in April 2026 that the tech center recruit River View charter students. Supported Tyson on financial-experience grounds. No articulated position on EFAs, charters or homeschooling in nine years of tape.                                                                       |
| Candace Crawford (board 1991 to 2002 per project briefing; appointed July 2023; elected 2024; Finance chair from 2025; chair since March 18, 2026)                | Not seated for the audit lapse or the three filings. Moved the January 2024 \$36.1 million budget that folded ESSER positions into operations, and the ESSER-funded modular purchase. Present without recorded objection for the March 2024 reversal of the retention. Spoke to the May 2025 trust withdrawals as "reimbursing ourselves from our savings account."                                                                                                                                     | Presented the audit history to the City Council; moved the forensic audit; opposed reinstating Sprague; voted against the three-school model and the 4–3 budget; wrote and carried the open-enrollment article. As chair, has the highest measured share of board speech and nonpublic-session rate of any era in the project's data. | The least open. Opposed Tyson because Lavalette "made a more persuasive argument in support of public education"; tied EdOpt to the Croydon budget cut; built the open-enrollment article to admit up to 10 percent in and let 0 percent out; said parents' use of homeschooling after discipline "infuriates me." |

### 3. Heather Whitney

#### Tenure

Elected March 2019, taking Michelle Pierce's seat; sworn in March 20, 2019 (Scripts/roster\_2015\_2023.md). Vice chair under Sprague from May 6, 2020 and under Petrin from April 6, 2022; chair from the March 2023 reorganization until March 18, 2026, when she moved Crawford's election as chair and lost a 3–3 vote for vice chair (Elite Theory Perspective, officers table; Claremont School Board, 3/18/26). She now sits on Finance, chairs the ad hoc reconfiguration committee and is the board's SREA negotiator (briefing.md, Addendum 1). Re-elected in 2021 and 2024.

#### Formation of the deficit

Whitney was on the board for every act in the timeline from 2019 onward, and an officer for all but the first.

- **The audit lapse, 2019.** Her first SAU 6 meeting, March 28, 2019, was the one at which the acting superintendent laid out a forensic audit and a \$5,000 efficiency study as alternatives, said a forensic audit “suits suspected wrongdoing” and that “to my knowledge, there’s no concern about that at this time,” and the board took up only the study and rejected it on a hand count; Whitney “questioned the study’s scope and timing before a new superintendent” (SAU 6, 3/28/19, 0:53:08 and participants table). On April 11, 2019 the study itself was deferred until Tempesta started; she joined the new SAU policy subcommittee (SAU 6, 4/11/19). On November 20, 2019 she sat through the auditor’s statement that Claremont was “one of our most delinquent clients in the history of a 40, 45 year firm” (Claremont School Board, 11/20/19, 0:12:21). No board member is recorded proposing a remedy that night.
- **The three filings, 2020 to 2022.** She was vice chair when the FY2020 and FY2021 balances were reported and applied (autumn 2020 and 2021) and vice chair under Petrin for the FY2022 filing (deficit timeline, acts 2 to 4). None of the three is on a minute, an agenda or a recorded vote. The auditor later said he had told management “for 20 and 21... to please be conservative” (Claremont School Board, 5/21/25, 0:39:21). The record does not show the warning reaching the board, and it does not show any officer asking for the audited number before the filing.
- **February 15, 2023.** The one roll call in the formation period. Skillen moved to restore \$600,000 to the default budget so that ESSER-funded positions would be carried when the grants expired, naming the risk as “a structural deficit”; it passed 4–2, Whitney and Horsky against (Claremont School Board, 2/15/23, 1:09:52; roll call 1:40:44). Her stated reason was not indifference to the cliff: she argued the default budget already funded every position and that adding money “to artificially inflate the default budget” would be “disingenuous” to voters who had just amended the proposed budget at the deliberative session (2/15/23, 1:22:18 to 1:23:36). The vote still stands as the one recorded occasion on which she opposed a measure taken expressly to guard against the deficit that followed.
- **As chair, 2023 to 2025.** She presided over the October 18, 2023 retention of \$424,000, taken on Henry’s warning that “I worry about if we’ve given back too much to the taxpayers on those audits” (10/18/23, 1:08:42; vote 1:17:38). That was the correct diagnosis and the right act. She then presided over its reversal on March 6, 2024, when Gallagher moved the \$420,000 into the general fund and the chair recorded “seeing no opposition, the motion passes” (3/6/24, 0:32:16; 0:35:51). The October reason, the missing audits, was not revisited. She presided over the January 17, 2024 adoption of \$36.1 million by uncounted voice vote, the October 16, 2024 retention of \$350,000 whose Department of Revenue Administration filing the district later blamed for a tax rate set too low, the January 7, 2025 budget built on a one-year \$1.9 million jump in state aid with the pre-K program eliminated over Hawkins’s written dissent and the Masonic Temple decided in nonpublic session, and the May 7, 2025 withdrawal of \$888,998 from five trust and reserve funds in five voice votes (deficit timeline, acts 8 to 12). The chair’s share of board speech in the 2023 and 2024 eras is .58 and rises to .65 in 2025 (signatures-by-era-claremont.csv).

What this adds up to: Whitney did not originate the mechanism, but she held the second or first chair through every year it ran, presided over the board’s single protective act and over its undoing, and chose or accepted uncounted voice votes for every one of those decisions. Her own later description is accurate as far as it goes: “We were following previous practices of the board, and not what we now know are best practices” (NH Journal, Sept. 7, 2025).

## The response

- **Disclosure and framing.** She announced the deficit on August 14, 2025 (“anywhere between 1 and \$5 million,” 0:22:29) and the same night said she “joined the board because I was so distressed that I had to send my daughter to private school” (0:49:05). Madden’s objection that “the presentation was somewhat deceptive” and that “we hid behind our lawyer” (0:30:10) was aimed at the framing she had presided over between April and August.

- **Investigation and policy.** She asked for an Attorney General investigation (“I personally believe the magnitude of our situation warrants an investigation”) and proposed requiring annual external audits and routing federal grant documentation to the board directly (NH Journal, Sept. 7, 2025). Both policies were adopted in September 2025 (deficit timeline, “What the board did that pointed the other way”). The state closed the statutory gap separately with SB 586 (2026 ch. 272).
- **Votes.** For the \$4 million reimbursement anticipation note, 6–0 (9/3/25, 2:59:39). Absent for the Bluff closure (9/17/25). For the revolving loan fund resolution, 6–0 (10/1/25). Moved the three-school model, which failed 3–4 (1/7/26; Valley News, Jan. 8, 2026). Moved the amended \$42,957,713 bottom line that passed 4–3, saying “the reason why we are in this financial crisis is because we’ve had abysmal administrators” (1/21/26, participants table; Valley News, Jan. 22, 2026). That sentence is the clearest statement by any of the three that responsibility lies with the administration rather than the board.
- **The Sprague reinstatement.** After the October 1 tie she telephoned the member who had resigned in August, asked “would do there any chance that you would do it?”, received his letter, read it into the record, seconded both reinstatement motions and voted yes, saying she would defer to the voters “because I find this appointment process a dirty process” (Vacancy discussion, 11/5/25, 0:12:13, 0:07:32, 0:11:12). The voters removed Sprague four months later (deficit timeline, March 10, 2026). Whatever one thinks of the outcome, the method was a private call by the presiding officer to a former officer, and it is the clearest example in the record of the self-selection of leadership that the Elite Theory Perspective report describes.
- **2026.** Out of the chair, her record is the most active of the three: 13 written questions to the auditor (8/5/26); repeated requests for vacancies mapped against Ed 306 minimum standards (5/20/26, 6/3/26); Right-to-Know requests filed while chair (6/3/26); a proposal to publish fulfilled Right-to-Know responses (4/1/26); the FY28 aid warning (8/19/26); the Hanover-style budget book (6/19/26). She was the only vote against three policies on September 16, 2026 “just because I have more questions” (9/16/26, participants table).

## Openness to competing modalities

Whitney is the one member of the three whose tape contains an argument for options beyond the district, and the one whose personal history includes them.

- August 5, 2020: affluent families facing remote or hybrid schooling “are sending their kids to private school... or they’re going to hire a nanny or au pair or a tutor,” and the district’s poorest students were being left without the same (Claremont School Board, 8/5/20, 1:59:58 to 2:00:36).
- September 2, 2020 and January 6, 2021: asked how homeschool withdrawal and re-entry work, and whether the district could “tap into the homeschooling network and curriculums” to help parents who felt they had become “the primary educator” (9/2/20, 0:47:42; 1/6/21, 2:20:53 to 2:22:07).
- October 20, 2021: brought a homeschool parent’s complaint about SAT access at Stevens to the agenda (10/20/21, 2:03:08 to 2:04:17).
- July 21, 2021, on the new EFA law: corrected the discussion by noting the income threshold, “it’s basically targeted for lower income families,” and added, “quite frankly I think that that’s the population least likely to use it” (7/21/21, 2:31:03 to 2:31:37). A factual point, mildly skeptical of take-up, not an argument against the program.
- March 1 and August 2, 2023, on River View: pointed to another program “which people don’t recognize as a charter school” and raised “partnering, partnering with with the charter school” for school-avoidant students (3/1/23, 0:54:06; 8/2/23, 2:28:44).

- October 16, 2024: moved the replacement of policy JJ, access to public school programs by nonpublic, charter and home-educated pupils, with the 2024 model (10/16/24, 1:40:46). A routine NHSBA update, but she carried it.
- September 30, 2024: complained that the state pays the district “roughly \$4,000” for a private-school student while “we have to provide all the services to that child out of our school budget” (joint meeting, 9/30/24, 1:06:57).
- October 1, 2025: relayed community concern that an EdOpt founder’s “purpose of you joining the board would be to disrupt public education” and asked him to answer it; asked the other applicant for his position on EFAs because “we’re under a lot of pressure with educational freedom accounts”; then voted for Tyson: “we are moving into a transformational period, and that we need people who think completely out of the box... public education is in a rut, and we could benefit from a person who has explored other educational opportunities and still has chosen to serve in the public school district” (10/1/25, 1:27:53, 1:08:51, 1:41:48 to 1:43:00).
- 2026: asked for the charter right-of-first-refusal process to be explained before Bluff and the Masonic Temple went to market (3/18/26, 1:52:27) and asked the state representative whether adequacy aid follows a Claremont student to the Newport charter (5/20/26, 0:13:52).

Assessment. Her openness is real but instrumental. She treats charters, homeschooling and private schools as facts the district must live with and sometimes use, and she reasons about each from its effect on the district’s revenue and obligations. She has not, on the record, argued for funding following the student, and her one EFA comment predicted low take-up. A voter who wants a board member who will not treat competing providers as enemies has evidence here; a voter who wants an advocate for choice does not.

## 4. Michael Petrin

### Tenure

Sworn in March 15, 2017. SAU 6 vice chair 2018–19 and SAU 6 chair from March 28, 2019. Claremont chair from April 6, 2022 until March 2023, when he lost the one-year seat to Gallagher; returned as a write-in in March 2024; vice chair from March 19, 2025 and still vice chair after a 3–3 vote on his own motion to step aside for Whitney (roster\_2015\_2023.md; Elite Theory Perspective, officers table; 3/18/26). Chairs the SRVRTC committee (briefing.md, Addendum 1).

### Formation of the deficit

- **The audit lapse.** He joined the board in the second of the three years without audits. On September 13, 2018 the business administrator told the SAU 6 board “we’re caught up in the saw... done through 17” (SAU 6, 9/13/18, 1:16:36); the FY2015 district audit was in fact finished in January 2019 and FY2016 was still open in February 2019 (Claremont School Board, 2/20/19, summary). Elected SAU 6 chair on March 28, 2019, he “supported the efficiency study” that night, when the acting superintendent had described a forensic audit as suited to “suspected wrongdoing” of which there was “no concern... at this time” and the study failed on a hand count (SAU 6, 3/28/19, 0:53:08); on April 11, 2019 he presided and “favored waiting on the efficiency study” until the new superintendent arrived, which the board then voted to do (SAU 6, 4/11/19, 0:49:36 to 1:03:12). The forensic option was never put to a vote. No efficiency study is mentioned again in 2019 or 2020 (Elite Theory Perspective, project notes). He answered the roll and said nothing else on November 20, 2019 when the auditor called the district “one of our most delinquent clients” (11/20/19, participants table).
- **The three filings.** A member for autumn 2020 and 2021 and the presiding officer for autumn 2022, the year in which about \$1.2 million was applied to the tax rate when the audit later showed a \$198,888 deficit (deficit timeline, act 4). He confirmed the board’s act himself three years on: “The vote was to give back 1.2 million. How

do we not trust the BA?” (10/1/25, 3:03:12). The chair’s share of board speech in the 2022 era was .51 and mentions of ESSER ran at 20.9 per ten hours, the highest of any era, so the grant money was being discussed at length under his chairmanship while the reimbursement position went unexamined (signatures-by-era-claremont.csv).

- **February 15 and March 1, 2023.** He presided over and voted for the \$600,000 restoration, and his questions that night show he understood the point: “if we move positions Esser funding, Esther is going to write out in two years... Those positions then... will need to continue” (2/15/23, 1:12:13). Two weeks later, presiding again, he heard the assistant superintendent report that only \$400,000 of a \$2.879 million ESSER 2 allocation had been reimbursed and that “I’ve never done Esser reporting, I’m not sure how that works actually” (3/1/23, 0:09:49). No board action followed.
- **Off the board, then back.** He was not a member for the October 2023 retention or its March 2024 reversal. He was a member, by voice vote, for the October 2024 retention, the January 2025 budget and pre-K elimination, and the May 2025 trust withdrawals, and on the last of these the recording shows him asking “Are we doing one motion at one at a time?” before the five withdrawals were taken in twelve minutes (5/7/25, 0:36:45; attribution caution on that page).

What this adds up to: of the three, Petrin has the longest exposure to the mechanism and the least recorded resistance to it. He held the SAU 6 chair when the audit question was deflected in 2019, the Claremont chair when the largest single over-return was filed in 2022, and he has said on tape that the board’s posture was to trust the business administrator’s number. His February 2023 vote is the one recorded act on the other side of the ledger, and it was a real one.

## The response

- For the note, 6–0 (9/3/25); for the Bluff closure, 4–1 (9/17/25); for the loan-fund resolution (10/1/25); for the three-school model (1/7/26); for the flat budget, on the ground that voters “are not tolerating a tax increase” and that ignoring them risks “putting the district in jeopardy” (Valley News, Jan. 22, 2026). Seconded the budget amendment and moved the Bluff and Maple Avenue sale articles (1/21/26). Called the petitioned budget cap a “Real threat” while saying he could support some cap (1/21/26).
- Moved Sprague’s reinstatement twice on November 5, 2025, and on October 1 had preferred sending the vacancy to the City Council rather than tabling it (10/1/25, 1:48:28). Volunteered for the superintendent and business administrator search committee and asked for a plain-language meeting on “what happened financially” (11/5/25, participants table). Asked on April 1, 2026 that matters reach the agenda through the chair rather than through the administration.
- His 2026 footprint is small. Absent December 17, 2025; “Answered the roll calls; one attributed word” on June 17, 2026; “Not separately identified in the dialogue file” on August 5; “Not identified on the recording” on September 2; one turn on September 16, on the mascot proposal (meeting pages). Some of this is the transcript’s failure to separate his voice, which the pages say; the minutes still record him seconding motions. But the pattern of a vice chair whose contribution the recording cannot find is consistent across the year.

## Openness to competing modalities

- December 20, 2017, when the superintendent called SB 193’s vouchers “the real scary piece”: asked only when the program would start (12/20/17, 1:56:12).

- November 7, 2018: argued for in-district special education programs on the ground that they prevent students “from being tuition out” (11/7/18, 1:25:55). Keeping students and their money inside the district is the consistent thread.
- October 1, 2025: seconded and voted for Tyson, explaining his support “along the lines of experience. Some experience with financials” (10/1/25, 1:41:24). He did not engage the EdOpt question either way.
- April 1, 2026: asked the tech center director “to reach out to the Riverview Charter School... They have some students down there that are interested in coming to the tech program, and they went k to eight within our schools. And they’ve chosen this other path, but they want to take advantage of the tech center” (4/1/26, 2:40:08). The most cooperative statement about a charter by any of the three, though it also brings enrollment to a district program.
- June 3, 2026: asked that the calendar align with Newport for the tech programs (6/3/26, participants table).

Assessment. Nine years of tape contain no statement of principle by Petrin on EFAs, charters, homeschooling or private schools. What is there is practical and not hostile: he will work with River View when it serves a district program and he voted for a choice advocate for reasons unrelated to choice. A voter cannot find in the record what he thinks the district owes a family that leaves it.

## 5. Candace Crawford

### Tenure

The project’s briefing records earlier service from 1991 to 2002 with six years as chair (briefing.md, Era 3; single-sourced, and the Valley News of July 21, 2023 says only “a former School Board member”). Appointed July 19, 2023 to Horsky’s seat, 4–2, Whitney and Sprague opposed (Valley News, July 21, 2023). Elected March 2024. Finance and Capital Improvements subcommittees from 2023; Capital Improvements chair from September 2024; Finance chair by autumn 2025; chair of the board since March 18, 2026 by voice vote on Whitney’s motion (briefing.md, Addenda 1 and 7; 3/18/26).

**A correction made to the project’s own timeline.** The September 1, 2026 deficit timeline’s roster table said Crawford “had been appointed 4–2 in April 2023.” The briefing, the Valley News and Horsky’s June 21, 2023 resignation on the record all put the appointment on July 19, 2023. The timeline’s roster row, its confidence note and its roster sources were corrected on September 28, 2026 and the page’s footer records the revision.

### Formation of the deficit

Crawford was not seated for the audit lapse, the three filings, the February 2023 roll call or the March 2023 ESSER report. Her exposure begins with the October 18, 2023 retention (act 7) and runs through the May 2025 withdrawals (act 12), all voice votes.

- January 17, 2024: moved the \$36,117,406.87 budget that folded ESSER-created positions into the operating budget, and earlier the same night moved “to use Esser funds to, to purchase a modular unit” for the Academy, one-time federal money committed to a capital asset (1/17/24, 2:23:10; deficit timeline, act 8).
- March 6, 2024: present when the \$420,000 retention was released with “no opposition” (3/6/24, 0:35:51). The record does not show her speaking to it.
- May 7, 2025: put the withdrawals in their best light: “these are expenses that already have been have occurred in this budget year, and we’re reimbursing ourselves from our savings account, if you will” (5/7/25; deficit timeline, act 12). She chaired Capital Improvements while the Masonic Temple was bought on the superintendent’s

recommendation in January 2025 and later questioned spending on it against the board's authorization (5/20/26, participants table); the record does not show what she knew of the purchase before it was made.

What this adds up to: Crawford arrived after the hole was dug and sat on the Finance subcommittee through the two years in which the district's own business administrator told the board the audits were missing and the balances might be wrong. Her recorded contributions in that period moved the budget and explained the withdrawals; none questioned the numbers.

## The response

- **The City Council presentation, September 2, 2025.** She traced the problem to 2016, when "audits were deferred by the then school administration," placed responsibility for initiating audits with the administration and said the board operates at its "mercy" for financial information. The Assistant Mayor answered: "You go three years before anyone realizes that (audits) didn't happen... To me that is a failure at the board level" (Valley News, Sept. 5, 2025). She also told the council the 2022 audit "showed a surplus that cleared the deficit"; the finalized audit presented four weeks later showed a \$198,888 deficit (10/1/25, 3:00:38). The audit was finalized between the two statements, so this is a draft figure overtaken rather than a misstatement.
- **Votes and motions.** For the note, putting its cost at "between 65 and \$75,000 of interest" (9/3/25). For the Bluff closure (9/17/25). Appointed a manifest signer (9/17/25, 2:05:45). Moved the forensic audit after the State Police asked for one (11/5/25, 1:43:10). Against reinstating Sprague, arguing for leaving the seat empty until March: "I was disappointed in Mr. Sprague for resigning at the time that he did" (Vacancy discussion, 11/5/25, 0:12:47). Against the three-school model and for both four-school models (1/7/26). Against the 4-3 budget because "\$865,000 is pretty unrealistic" to find in 24 hours and because athletics should be a separate warrant article (1/21/26; Valley News, Jan. 22, 2026). Wrote and presented the open-enrollment article (2/7/26, 2/18/26).
- **As chair, 2026.** The project's era measures give the 2026 era, sixteen meetings under Crawford, a chair share of board speech of .70, the highest of any era since 2014, a board Gini of .55, the most unequal, and 17.5 nonpublic sessions per ten hours, also the highest; public turns fell from 381 per ten hours in 2025 to 126 (signatures-by-era-claremont.csv; the measures are computed from machine-diarized transcripts and the Elite Theory Perspective report states their limits). The meeting pages record the behavior behind the numbers: she "prefers to write the subcommittee's minutes herself" (6/19/26); "added a nonpublic session to the agenda without a motion" and "asked that requests to the administration go through the chair" (6/3/26); "proposed every subcommittee assignment" and "proposed an ad hoc committee in place of a vote" on the by-laws (3/18/26); "announced there would be no superintendent evaluation this year" (5/20/26). Each of these has a defensible governance reading, and a single channel to the administration is the NHSBA norm. Together they describe a chair who has concentrated the board's voice and process in the office, which is the pattern the Elite Theory Perspective report identifies as preceding the deficit.
- **Substance.** On August 5, 2026 she walked the public through the fund-balance mechanism and said the word "falsification," which the auditor softened to "misrepresentation" (8/5/26, 0:56:00 to 0:56:47). She asked for "a verified July 1, 2025 opening balance" (6/3/26) and gave the public four cautions for reading the draft audits (7/21/26). She has been the board's most fluent explainer of the arithmetic since Angell left.

## Openness to competing modalities

- **October 1, 2025.** To Tyson: "I am perplexed, where that organization, tried to eliminate the cordon school budget. And, you're affiliated with that project"; after his denial, "It seems like that's your, outlook for public education" (1:32:11 to 1:33:02). Speaking for Lavalette: "he made a more persuasive argument in support of public education. We are here to support public education... we don't need more chaos" (1:40:48). On the facts: the Croydon cut

was moved at the March 2022 town meeting by Ian Underwood, a selectman, whose wife Jody Underwood chaired the Croydon school board (NHPR, March 31, 2022); EdOpt was founded in 2024 and Jody Underwood is its president (EdOpt, About page). Crawford's claim that the organization "tried to eliminate" the budget is wrong on the date and the actor; her underlying association between EdOpt's leadership and Croydon is not baseless.

- **The open-enrollment article, February 2026.** The article she wrote designates all district schools open-enrollment under RSA 194-D, admits nonresidents up to 10 percent of each school's enrollment, and limits residents attending open-enrollment schools elsewhere "to 0%" (2/18/26, 0:01:57). Her stated purpose: without a vote the district "would be responsible for 80% of the costs of students going to another district," so "It is important for Claremont to support this article to protect its own budget and costs" (2/18/26, 0:02:48 to 0:06:32). Voters approved it. The design is defensive by construction: it takes in tuition-bearing students and closes the exit.
- **Homeschooling, July 29, 2026.** "parents say, oh, will homeschool them and don't do anything. And then then they come back to school after a year and they're one year behind... that infuriates me because parents are allowed to use homeschooling as an easy way to, ameliorate the problem, to get away, to not solve anything" (goal-setting session, 7/29/26, 1:21:40 to 1:22:15). The context was discipline cases and re-entry, not homeschooling generally, and she said "Whatever the reason is that parents choose homeschooling, the reentry into the public school is is problematic" (1:23:27). It is still the only statement by any of the three that treats a family's choice as an imposition on the district.
- **The superintendent interview, April 6, 2026.** She read submitted questions casting school choice as introducing "winners and losers" and asking whether the candidate supports proposals "that divert public tax dollars to private entities and hurt communities like Claremont" (4/6/26, 0:22:35, 0:30:36). She was reading, not speaking, and the page credits her with alternating floor and online questions fairly. Her own questions concerned the zero-tuition article, residence and trust.
- **On the other side.** She responded to Petrin's firefighting-program idea by saying it had been in the tech center plan until the cuts (4/1/26, 2:41:09), and she moved the \$17,000 tuition rate for incoming students (11/5/25). She supports programs that bring students in.

Assessment. Crawford is the institutional defender of the three. Her stated test for a board member is persuasiveness "in support of public education," she reads a choice organization as a threat first, and her one structural initiative on enrollment was built to keep students from leaving. None of this is hidden; she says it in public and the voters ratified the article. A voter who wants the district defended against competing providers has the clearest candidate here. A voter who wants the district to treat those providers as part of the same community does not.

## 6. What the three have in common

From January 31, 2018 to March 18, 2026, four people held every chair and vice-chair term on the Claremont board: Sprague, Zullo, Whitney and Petrin. Two of the three members now up for election were among them, and the third, Crawford, is a former chair returned after two decades and installed as chair within two years of her appointment (Elite Theory Perspective, "The stability of leadership and the choosing of successors"). Whitney and Petrin sat through the whole formation of the deficit and were the vice chair and the chair for its largest single act. Crawford was chosen by the board rather than the voters, as five of the seat changes between 2016 and 2025 were.

The blocs that formed in the crisis run through all three. Whitney, Petrin and Madden voted together for Tyson, for Sprague's reinstatement, for the three-school model and for the flat budget; Crawford and Hawkins voted against each, with Howard joining them on the appointment, the three-school model and the budget and abstaining on Sprague. The alignment is not personal loyalty: Whitney moved Crawford's election as chair, and Whitney and Sprague had voted

against Crawford’s appointment in 2023. It is a division over how much the district should change its shape and its relations with the administration, and it will be on the ballot in March.

On the first question the request asked, none of the three has said in public that the board, as distinct from the administration, failed. Whitney’s “abysmal administrators,” Crawford’s “mercy” of the administration and Petrin’s “How do we not trust the BA?” are the same answer in three registers. The Assistant Mayor’s reply of September 2, 2025 remains unanswered on the record.

## 7. What the record cannot show

- The three autumn filings that opened roughly \$2.29 million of the deficit have no minutes, no agenda and no recorded vote; the pre-2023 recordings carry no captions and could not be transcribed. Whitney and Petrin are placed at those decisions by roster, not by tape. A Right-to-Know request for the September to November 2020, 2021 and 2022 minutes and the MS-25 and DOE-25 packets would close the gap (deficit timeline, “What the record does not show”).
- Every retention, reversal, budget adoption and trust withdrawal between October 2023 and May 2025 was an uncounted voice vote. Whitney presided over all of them and Crawford was present for all of them; how either voted is not recoverable, and this evaluation does not claim to know.
- The forensic audit engaged in April 2026 covers January 2019 to December 2025 and had published no findings as of this date. Nothing here is a finding of wrongdoing by any named person.
- Speaker attribution in the dialogue files is machine-made. Quotations were re-read in context; where a page flags a misattribution near a cited passage, this document follows the page.
- The author’s interest is stated in section 1. The October 1, 2025 exchange is the best evidence on the third question and the evidence least separable from that interest.

## Sources

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Output/Reports/The-Elite-Theory-Perspective.HTML (September 27, 2026): officers table 2015 to 2026, era measures, appointments 2016 to 2025.

Output/Reports/signatures-by-era-claremont.csv (Scripts/era\_signatures.py, September 27, 2026): chair share, Gini, roll calls, voice votes, nonpublic sessions and public turns per era.

Output/HTML meeting pages and Output/HTML/Dialogue transcripts cited by date: SAU 6 9/13/18, 3/28/19, 4/11/19; Claremont School Board 12/20/17, 11/7/18, 2/20/19, 11/20/19, 8/5/20, 9/2/20, 1/6/21, 7/21/21, 10/20/21, 2/15/23, 3/1/23, 8/2/23, 10/18/23, 1/17/24, 3/6/24, 9/30/24 (joint), 10/16/24, 1/7/25, 5/7/25, 5/21/25, 8/14/25, 9/3/25, 9/17/25, 10/1/25, 11/5/25 (meeting and vacancy excerpt), 11/19/25, 12/3/25, 12/17/25, 1/7/26, 1/21/26, 2/7/26, 2/18/26, 3/18/26, 4/1/26, 4/6/26, 5/20/26, 6/3/26, 6/17/26, 6/19/26, 7/21/26, 7/29/26, 8/5/26, 8/12/26, 8/19/26, 9/2/26, 9/16/26.

Scripts/briefing.md (Addenda 1, 2, 7) and Scripts/roster\_2015\_2023.md: rosters, officers, the July 19, 2023 appointment vote, the March 2024 election.

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## Press

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## Statutes

RSA 194-D (open enrollment); RSA 198:4-b and 198:5 (retention of unassigned fund balance); RSA 21-J:19 (audits); RSA 671:33 (school board vacancies); 2 CFR 200.512(a)(1) (single audit submission); SB 586, 2026 ch. 272 (annual audits, RSA 198:4-d).